

In the field

In return for protection and the right to work their lands, peasants worked for the lord of the manor for an agreed number of days per year, as well as giving him a share of their produce.

Viking leader called Rollo agreed to give up raiding the coasts of France in return for the right to settle with his followers in the northern part of the country (see pp.202–03). Rollo became the vassal of the Carolingian ruler, Charles the Simple, and his people became known as the Normans. In 1066, Duke William of Normandy invaded England (see pp.192–93), became its king, and granted lands to many of his Norman followers in return for their fulfillment of feudal obligations. From this time onward, feudalism was firmly implanted in England.

Much of the rest of northern Europe was made up of a patchwork of smaller states, particularly those that formed part of the mainly Germanic Holy Roman Empire. Here the overlapping rights and responsibilities of emperor,



dukes, and other secular and ecclesiastical princes made the political system more complex.

Knighthood and chivalry

The medieval knight fitted broadly into this system of feudal obligation. Having evolved initially from the heavy cavalry who had accompanied rulers such as Charlemagne, by the 11th century the knights had come to represent a distinct caste of professional fighting men. Their status was confirmed and enhanced through symbols and public ceremonies such as the “accolade”—a girding with a sword or hand on the shoulder. In return for this special status, the knight was expected to fight for his lord and to defend those groups, such as the clergy and the poor, who relied on his protection. The 12th-century writer John of Salisbury defined the knight’s duties as being “to guard the church, to fight unbelievers, to venerate the priesthood, to protect the poor from injuries, to pour out their blood for their brothers.”

Inevitably, the reality of knightly conduct did not always match up to this chivalric code. Toward the latter part of this period, in particular, feudal obligations were superseded by monetary arrangements. By the 14th century, knights would expect to be paid for their service and could themselves often pay a shield tax in lieu of service. Nonetheless, throughout this period knights remained a social and military elite.

The castle

Castles were the headquarters of the medieval feudal system. A castle was a multipurpose building. It was the home of a lord, his

“The **faithful vassal** should ... counsel and aid his lord.”

FULBERT OF CHARTRES, LETTER TO DUKE WILLIAM OF AQUITAINE, 1020 CE

family, and his servants. It was where business was done, the lord met his vassals, and courts of justice met. It was also a military base and a fortified building from which a whole region could be defended.

Some castles were royal residences. In a period when communications were poor, the best way for a monarch to exercise power in the kingdom was to travel continuously, so rulers usually had castles around the kingdom. Other strongholds were held by vassals on the king’s behalf, who ruled as a part of their feudal duties. A castle usually had a courtyard (bailey), surrounded by a strong, fortified wall. Inside the bailey was the main accommodation, a grand hall and private rooms for the lord or king, heated by open fires and decorated with tapestries. In the towers or outer buildings were less luxurious rooms for the stables, garrison, and service buildings.

ENGLISH KING (1027–87 CE)

WILLIAM THE CONQUEROR

William, Duke of Normandy, invaded England in 1066, defeated his English rival, Harold, in battle at Hastings, and became William I. He introduced feudal government to England and appointed many French noblemen as his vassals, meaning that the ruling class of England was mainly Norman for many years. William and his nobles built many castles, and he commissioned a famous survey, the *Domesday Book*, detailing the lands and wealth of his kingdom.



AFTER

The feudal system gradually died out as traders and merchants grew more powerful, and printing led to greater exchange of ideas.

CHANGES IN FEUDAL SERVICE

During the 14th and 15th centuries social changes made **feudal relations decline in importance**. Increasingly, vassals paid feudal dues in money rather than by military service. At the same time, the **middle classes**, who made their living by buying and selling goods, became more powerful.

RENAISSANCE

Writers and artists began to look back to ancient Greece and Rome for inspiration. This cultural rebirth, or **Renaissance 250–55**, resulted in a new realism in painting, changes in architectural styles, and translations of classic texts.

SPREAD OF PRINTING

Around 1438, German metalworker Johannes Gutenberg invented a method of making metal printing type. This allowed printing of books and the **rapid circulation of ideas** in Europe.

The inner bailey walls or courtyard housed the hall and other buildings to provide accommodation for the king’s household, guests, and armed garrison.

Halberd

The halberd was carried by foot-soldiers, who inflicted serious injuries with its sharp point. They also used the weapon to trip or maim a horse or to pull a knight off his mount.

Horseman’s hammer

The hammer pick or spike was used to penetrate gaps between armored areas or to smash straight through armored plate.

Mace

With its pointed blades, or flanges, a mace like this was a powerful weapon, even piercing plate armor if swung with enough force.